

Exploring the Hijra community through colonial, racial, binary, and heteronormative discourses

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Abstract

This paper examines the intersection of colonial, racial, binary, and heteronormative discourses affecting the Hijra community in British-colonized India. Using feminist and postcolonial frameworks, it explores the marginalization and demonization of Hijras, analyzing how they have been portrayed as deviant within patriarchal and colonial narratives. The discussion employs Kimberlé Crenshaw's intersectionality framework to dissect the multifaceted discrimination Hijras faced, considering structural, political, and representational intersections.

Moreover, this study investigates the combined impact of the male and colonizer gazes, exemplified by British portrayals that framed Hijras as exoticized or dehumanized figures, reinforcing the colonial agenda of erasure. The British criminalization of Hijra customs under policies such as the Criminal Tribes Act and Section 377 further curtailed their social and economic roles. Analyzing literature and media, the paper highlights postcolonial and feminist critiques of these narratives, suggesting that the resilience of the Hijra community represents a

challenge to entrenched binaries and hegemonic masculinities imposed by colonial powers. This paper emphasizes the importance of understanding Hijras' complex experiences as part of broader movements for identity reclamation and equality within postcolonial societies.

Keywords

Hijra community, Indian society, postcolonialism, feminism, intersectionality, colonial discourse, heteronormativity, gender binarism, symbolic oppression, power dynamics, credibility, status, India, British colonialism, racialization, gender inequality, male gaze, colonizer gaze, hegemonic masculinity, identity erasure, Criminal Tribes Act, Victorian morality.

Introduction

What connection exists between feminism and postcolonialism if colonialism is related to postcolonialism as patriarchy is to feminism? Several academics have centred the theoretical discussion on the points where the mechanisms of symbolic oppression converge on the relationships between postcolonialism and feminism (Riyal, A.L.M., 2019).

Feminist and postcolonial analyses are complimentary from different angles. In contrast to the latter, which has an imperialist subject as its focus, the former has the objective of deconstructing the patriarchal subject. Postcolonial literature has witnessed a significant role in exploring the intersections of ethnicity, class, and gender, and this has been primarily accomplished at the level of symbolic representation.

“Thus, postcolonial theory - as epistemology, ethics, and politics, - addresses matters of identity, gender, race, racism and ethnicity with the challenges of developing a postcolonial national identity, of how a colonized people’s knowledge about the world is generated underspecific relations between the powerful and the powerless, circulated repetitively and finally legitimated in service to certain imperial interests” (Sawant, D., 2011: 5).

In this essay I will argue that the Hijras in particular suffer from distinct implications since they are the subjects of a propagandistic and demonizing discourse and have been sexualized and racialized. Steeped in rich social and cultural significance, also known as intersex, transgender, transsexual, or cross-dresser individuals, they have long challenged the binary notions of gender and have been marginalized and subjected to various forms of discrimination and

oppression. However, their existence and resilience defied not only the binary and heteronormative norms of gender and sexuality, but also the colonial and racial discourses that have shaped India’s social and cultural landscape. Whilst considering the historical contexts, throughout this essay I will seek to shed light on the ways in which the Hijras navigated the complexities of various intersecting forms of oppression.

Discussion

Kimberlé Crenshaw (1991) described the diverse ways that race, and gender interact to define the many elements that characterise the work experience of Black women. I will use her work as a source in this essay to analyse the interaction between British and Hijras through the intersectionality lens.

Crenshaw outlined three possible analytical uses for intersectionality: structural, political, and representational. The first category involves examining how multiple forms of discrimination mutually reinforce each other to create structural inequalities faced by Hijras and other marginalized groups. For instance, the community often faces discrimination and exclusion based on their gender identity and expression, as well as their caste and religious background. Analysing the structural intersections of these various forms of discrimination can be used as a framework for the difficulties faced by Hijras in accessing social, economic, and political opportunities.

Political intersectionality instead focuses on how intersecting inequalities shape political strategies and opportunities for social mobilization and coalition-building. It involves underlining how different organizations, such as LGBTQIA+ groups, feminist movements, and anti-caste movements, may intersect or diverge in their approaches to addressing the discrimination encountered by Hijras, as they struggle in finding inclusive spaces within LGBTQIA+ movements that may not adequately address their specific concerns related to caste, religion, or other factors. Understanding the political intersections of different social movements can help in developing effective strategies for socio-political change.

The third mode, namely representational intersectionality, is the convergence of racial and gender stereotypes in popular culture and the media that support the devaluation of violence against Black women, in Crenshaw's analysis, and Hijras in the present essay.

It is imperative to emphasise the male gaze theory's relevance to this essay. Laura Mulvey initially established the theory in her seminal essay "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975). She contends that males are positioned as the active viewers or protagonists whereas women are frequently depicted in popular media as objects to be gazed upon and framed by the male gaze.

According to this theory, the male gaze reinforces and perpetuates gender inequality by reducing women to passive objects, and by promoting a patriarchal view of women as primarily objects

of male desire rather than fully realized human beings with agency, autonomy, and subjectivity (Mulvey, L., 1975). The colonizer gaze, on the other hand, is a term used in postcolonial studies to describe the Eurocentric perspective and representation of colonized people as exotic, inferior, and "other" (Bouregbi, S., 2019).

The two gazes intersect and reinforce each other in their relation to Hijras, as the latter are often portrayed as objects of curiosity, fascination, or ridicule, through the lens of both male authors and filmmakers and the colonial legacy. E.M. Forster's "A Passage to India" is an example of how colonisers frequently portrayed indigenous or marginalised communities, maintaining negative preconceptions (Khan, N. U., & Khan, A. H., 2020). In the book, they are described in a dehumanising and objectifying manner. Such representations in literature and the media exacerbate the stigmatisation and prejudice, contributing to the social marginalisation and oppression of these communities. They are often pictured as effeminate, flamboyant, and hypersexualized characters, reduced to mere caricatures or objects of fetishization, reinforcing gender binarism and perpetuating societal norms which stigmatize the Hijra community.

However, there are also examples of postcolonial literature and media that challenge the male gaze and colonizer gaze in the representation of Hijras, such as "A Life in Trans Activism" (Rēvati, A. & Murali, N., 2016). This book is an autobiography of a Hijra activist from South India that provides an insider's perspective on their culture and experiences. Rēvati shares her personal journey

and hurdles as a Hijra, presenting a complex and humanizing portrayal that goes beyond exoticization or objectification.

The concept that the Hijra community in British-colonized India has been a central push in subverting colonial, racial, binary and heteronormative discourses has its roots in their resistance against oppressive systems during the colonial era. With their origins deeply embedded in Hindu texts and art, they embody the profound intermingling of man and woman, as evident in cosmogonic mythology and epics like the Ramayana and Mahabharata (Jajoo, P., 2020). The community's role during the colonial era was a seismic force, challenging not only traditional notions of private identities, behaviours, and sexual orientations, but also upending the very foundations of gender expression and social class belonging. The Hijras, who wear women's clothing and adopt female names, represent a structured hierarchical community that is led by a guru. Their bodies, defying the limits of gender binarism, posed a formidable revolution in both private and public spheres.

The Hijra community evoked specific concerns among the English colonizers. The collision of instincts and institutions with the Hijra community reached its topical moment during the Victorian morality era, when the British exerted an increased control over India (Hylton, S., Gettleman, J., & Lyons, E., 2018). The British criminalized their practices, including their traditional roles as performers, healers, and protectors of certain religious spaces, leading to clashes between the community and the colonial

institutions (Hinchy, J., 2020). This issue revealed profound processes of signification and power dynamics. In the context of colonialism, power dynamics between colonizers and colonized peoples were often expressed through gender hierarchies. These hierarchies positioned colonized men as weak and effeminate, while portraying women as sexual objects.

Today, this mentality persists, with Europeans being considered more masculine than Asians, while African men are often viewed as embodying an excessive or disproportionate level of masculinity, a product of Western projections. Gender metaphors continue to shape the political representations of the descendants of European colonizers in contemporary society, and these representations are often internalized by the oppressed. The phallogentric dimension of this dynamic positions men as having power over women, while simultaneously undermining non-normativity, such as that of the Hijras. In the eyes of the colonizers, they were a "male" community disguised in "female" attire and marginalized in society, branded by the British as "sodomites" and "perverse" (Hinchy, J., 2017).

Hence, the British used language as a tool to delegitimize their identity. Such denial of their gender and sexuality was a form of violence, in an effort to enforce a binary norm of man/woman. The aforementioned reasons behind the use of such derogatory language can be analysed through the lenses of Connell and Messerschmidt. In their publication titled "Hegemonic Masculinity: Rethinking the Concept," they argue that language plays a

significant role in constructing and enforcing hegemonic masculinity, which is often associated with power, privilege, and control (Connell, R. W., & Messerschmidt, J. W., 2005).

When the highest authorities of executive power endorse specific values through their speech and actions, the impact can be profound. This has been evident in various historical contexts, including colonised India, the Latin American colonies, and in present-day Brazil, among others. By way of illustration, I will refer to the 38th president of Brazil, Jair Bolsonaro. By making jokes that are misogynistic, racist, or homophobic, he legitimizes violence against these vulnerable segments of society, in a country where the number of feminicides and murders of transgender individuals is exceptionally high.

However, language's impact is felt not only in institutional and political contexts, but also in our daily lives: Connell and Messerschmidt perspective on masculinity (2005) serves as a thought-provoking starting point to illustrate an additional and more quotidian example of how language is used to normalise violence. Phrases like "boys will be boys" or "man up" are frequently employed in everyday conversations and can justify harmful behaviours like sexual harassment or assault as being a natural part of masculine culture. By normalising aggression, dominance, and violence as natural attributes in men, this discourse implies that efforts to restrain these instincts are futile.

Furthermore, it is important to examine the power dynamics between colonizer and colonized, including the ways in which British

imposed their notions of submission and dominance on indigenous Indian communities, and how such communities resisted, negotiated, and sometimes adapted to these power dynamics.

The British arrogated the power to legislate against the Hijras in an effort to exert control over them.

"From when Section 377 was implemented in 1858 to when it was recently deemed unconstitutional on 6 September 2018, Section 377 was used as justification to mistreat and punish Hijras, queers, and the LGBTQ+ community" (UAB, 2018).

Moreover, castes and communities considered "criminal" were subject to the Criminal Tribes Act (CTA) of 1871 (Safdar, A., 2020). The latter was a discriminatory law and a component of a larger colonial social control and racial categorization programme in India. The British, when legislating, had two main goals: one was to completely eradicate the sociocultural community of Hijras by outlawing their typical activities, such as dancing, singing, and wearing women's clothing in public, which the British considered to be immoral activities. The modes of erasure, on the other hand, represented the second goal, which was to make Hijras less visible, for example addressing them using masculine pronouns, and taking away from them any revenue that might have made them thrive within society. These "deviations" from binarism and heteronormativity, as observed among the Hijras, thus challenged Victorian British morality (Bhatt A., 2018).

The primary reason behind the intolerance of British officers and administration towards cross-dressing, which was deemed "obscene" and "uncivilized," particularly when practiced in

public spaces, was driven by the open display of a non-heteronormative and inherent sexuality, challenging established identity-based norms (Hinchy, J., 2014).

The Hijra, who were only trying to express their true selves, were not provided any viable options that would have allowed them to navigate their identity without undermining the cultural and political control of the colonial regime. Thus, their expression of a gender identity that went beyond binarism represented an affront to the British Raj. Consequently, the Hijra were expected to conform to the English expectations: colonial ambition drove the British to shape India in their image, moulding the identity and mindset of its people to fit their notion of “civilization” (Khan, N. U., & Khan, A. H., 2020).

Even though the CTA was passed with the previously mentioned objectives in mind, its actual effects fell short of expectations. The Hijra community’s ability to endure the criminalization of the CTA envisaged several tactics to lessen the effects of colonialism and the legislation. They were able to take advantage of the administrative power gaps that the British had themselves inadvertently created. Many Hijra rituals, such as begging and passing down oral traditions, had not been deemed illegal, while the community’s primary source of income, namely the performances, had. Therefore, through the other small, allowed acts they were able to evade authority and subvert the intent of the law by legalising their own existence in society and providing for themselves at the same time (Hinchy, J., 2014).

The discourse on English civilization goes further to address the idea of masculinity, viewed as a collection of stereotyped behaviours and traits, as opposed to femininity, which has been explored in gender studies literature, including the influential work of Judith Butler. In particular, “Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity” (Butler, J., 2008) challenges the binary construction of gender as male and female, and argues that gender is performative, meaning it is constructed through social and cultural norms and expectations. According to the author, gender entails a “stylized repetition of acts [...] compelled by sanction and taboo” (Butler, J., 1988: 519-520).

Butler’s work examines how masculinity and femininity are not inherent traits, but rather are socially constructed through repeated performances of gender. She critiques the idea of fixed and essentialist notions of masculinity and femininity, and argues that gender is fluid and contingent, shaped by power relations, cultural norms, and social expectations. In the context of British colonialism in India, the construction of masculinity as a collection of stereotyped behaviours and traits played a significant role in the interactions between British colonizers, Indian elites, and indigenous communities. British colonizers imposed their own notions of masculinity on the colonized, as part of the broader project of colonialism, which sought to establish dominance and control.

Hegemonic masculinity, as conceptualized by R.W. Connell (2005), refers to such set of characteristics associated with the dominant

group of men in a society, and which are deemed superior to other forms of masculinity or femininity. Hijras faced stigmatization, violence, and discrimination, as they do not conform to the dominant norms of hegemonic masculinity. The presence of individuals whose gender, sexual orientation, and practices challenged established norms not only threatened the Englishmen's control over the population, but also undermined their masculinity, virility, and traditional symbols of manhood associated with being heteronormative. Hijras regularly evoke feelings of fear and unease in the communities in which they reside.

The primary causes for these emotions can be presumed to be the fear of losing control over the populations' gender norms and sexuality, the unfamiliarity with their gender identity, or the belief in the Hijras' supernatural ability to curse. These fears can also be seen as a reflection of the societal dominance of patriarchy, which seeks to maintain control over women's roles and behaviours.

Depending on elements including region, caste, religion, and social class, the experience of being a Hijra might differ significantly. Hijras from diverse origins may have distinct social and economic prospects, and they may have distinct cultural practices and languages. Notably, literature produced during the colonial period in India often reflected the intersectionality of gender with other forms of oppression, such as caste and class. Writers like Mahasweta Devi, a prominent Bengali writer and social activist, addressed the issues faced by marginalized and

oppressed women, particularly those belonging to lower castes and tribes, and highlighted their struggles against gender-based discrimination and violence.

Drawing on the contributions of scholars such as Crenshaw (1991) and McCall (2005), an intersectional lens provides a comprehensive and nuanced approach to analysing the experiences of Hijras under British colonialism, by highlighting the importance of considering the intersecting dynamics of different forms of oppression and power and offering insights for understanding the complexities of Hijras' lives in the colonial context.

Conclusions

The laws and efforts aimed at suppressing a community of individuals who challenged the Eurocentric concepts of gender and sexuality are a testament to the concerns caused by the Hijra in the colonial era (Schmale, W., & Heise, B., 2016). Through their embodiment of non-conforming identities, they defied the prevailing European discourses on gender, proving that a new, more encompassing gender paradigm was needed.

The experiences of the community highlight how issues of legitimacy, racial superiority, heteronormativity, and binarism are immutably intertwined and inseparable.

Notwithstanding difficult circumstances, the Hijra community has survived and is still present in India and its bordering states today. There have also been recent successes in advocating for the

rights of the Hijra people in India. The “third gender,” which refers to the Hijra and other communities, was made lawful and is now present in documents and passports (Libretexts, 2020).

Another significant turning point was the “Right of Transgender Persons Bill,” which passed in 2016 and made various forms of discrimination against Hijras illegal (ICJ, 2016). Additionally, the bill has led to the creation of a committee that focuses on supporting Hijras in their pursuit of education through scholarships, grants, and other resources; a change that has resulted due to the recognition of Hijras as “socially and economically disadvantaged,” making them eligible for benefits under India’s Affirmative Action program (UAB, 2018). Despite these positive developments, it is evident that Hijras continue to face significant challenges in modern times.

Addressing these issues will require sustained legal efforts, public relations campaigns, and societal acceptance to create a society that fully embraces and supports all individuals, irrespective of their sexual or gender orientation.

To sum and conclude, in this essay I argued that the prevaricator action of colonial policies appeared strong in the cultural sphere, aiming at the erasure of traditions, at the interpretation of Brown as opposed to White, and of non-binary to binary, of non-hegemonic masculinity to hegemonic masculinity. The Hijra community’s strong response against colonialist erasure demonstrates their resistance to British authority

and their assertion of self-determination over their bodies.

The self-determination displayed by their collective identity as a community has been a significant factor in subverting colonial, racial, heteronormative, and binary discourses. I believe that bodies are the essential components that underpin self-determination. They are not only our own, but also function as a channel to interact with the world and are heavily influenced by it. The body is primarily the embodiment of subjectivity, an essential tool for understanding and constructing reality.

With their resistance, Hijras demonstrated how the body is the physical space in which we can create a revolution and establish the basic building blocks of defining ourselves socially and politically. However, if the media’s representation of the body changes the perception of our value as individuals, we need to work to emancipate ourselves from the grip that such ideas can hold on to our psyches. To achieve this, we must break away from the male gaze’s standards and instead adopt a new perspective that goes beyond the stereotypical and sexualized image of individuals.

Questioning the standardized image of bodies in narratives and the collective imagination provides an opportunity for discourse and research, as the Hijras experience shows. Throughout the course of my research, I have gained an understanding of the intricacies involved in conceptualizing Hijra identities within the context of British colonialism. I have come to understand how the Hijra community has managed to create and maintain self-representations despite the

oppressive rule of the British. Additionally, my work has enabled me to make scholarly connections and contextualize the discrimination and stigma faced by this marginalized group.

It is my hope that this research emphasizes the importance of intersectionality and geopolitics in understanding these issues. As the digital revolution and entertainment continue to shape public perceptions and representations of marginalized communities, how can we harness the power of these platforms to elevate the voices and experiences of Hijras and other non-heteronormative individuals? How can we use the strength of our own bodies to fight against oppressive structures? Still relevant today, an important lesson about self-determination is left behind by the Hijra community - our bodies are not just temples and homes, but battlefields for resistance, in a world that attempts to control and regulate them.

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